Sharif and then Kabul, but by the time it reached the troubled Soviet Central Asian republics, the whole shipment was looted. 'It was the saga of the most incredible measure', recalls Nambiar, who was responsible for tracking the progress of the shipment.[45]

On 30 August 1992, Burhanuddin Rabbani, the new president of Afghanistan, sought a re-fuelling stopover in New Delhi on his way to the NAM Summit in Jakarta. While the MEA officers dealing with the issue (especially Bhadrakumar and then 'acting' foreign secretary Srinivasan) many in New Delhi's power corridors were against the idea of hosting 'Wahhabis' in Delhi as state guests.[46] Rao, however, accepted the request. India hosted Rabbani and a 'plane-load of Mujahideen' commanders including, as Bhadrakumar notes, 'some frightening names vowed to eternal enmity toward India'.[47] Srinivasan received the delegation at the Palam airport, and held talks with them. Srinivasan describes them as confidence-building measures to assure Rabbani that the Mujahideen in Kabul and the Indian government were comfortable working with each other.[48]

Calling it a huge step forward, Srinivasan describes Rabbani's visit that summer as a bonus for India. He says:

> It showed that the Rabbani government was inclined on having some dealings with us [India], and that they were not entirely in the pockets of the Pakistanis—which is very helpful ... It suited us very well ... maybe we didn't make more of it, but I think at that time it was a great bonus as far as we were concerned.[49]

To reciprocate the visit, in September, then diplomat and now-vice president Hamid Ansari flew in an Indian air force plane to Mazar-e-Sharif from Delhi with caches full of medical supplies (Nambiar had joined Ansari from Kabul), and met with Dostum and gave him the supplies.[50] While in Kabul, Nambiar, who till now had been actively engaging with Najibullah and his officials, began building a strong rapport with Mojaddedi's deputy foreign minister, a tall Popalzai Pashtun from Kandahar, named Hamid Karzai, who would later become Afghanistan's president in 2001, and form a powerful bond with India.[51] In mid-July 1993, the foreign ministers of India and Afghanistan (Dinesh Singh and Hedayat Amin Arsala respectively) met in New York to consolidate ties further.[52]